

Picky Eaters: 20 Recipes Kids Will Actually Eat

15 Everyday Favorites + 5 Sweet Treats, All Nutritious

(Approximate nutrition per serving; portions sized for a child.)

Part 1: 15 Everyday Savory Favorites

1. Cheesy Paneer Paratha

Calories: 220 | **Protein:** 10g | **Fat:** 9g | **Carbs:** 26g

Ingredients: - Whole wheat dough - 50g grated paneer, 1 tbsp grated cheese, mild spices

Procedure: Mix paneer, cheese and mild spices for the stuffing. Roll into wheat dough, cook on tawa with a little ghee until golden on both sides. A guaranteed favorite.

2. Vegetable Pasta in Tomato Sauce

Calories: 240 | **Protein:** 8g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 38g

Ingredients: - 1/2 cup pasta (whole wheat if possible) - Finely chopped carrot, capsicum, sweet corn - Simple homemade tomato sauce

Procedure: Boil pasta until soft. Sauté finely chopped vegetables, add tomato sauce, simmer 5 minutes, toss in cooked pasta. A familiar dish kids rarely refuse.

3. Crispy Vegetable Cutlets

Calories: 160 | **Protein:** 4g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 22g

Ingredients: - Boiled and mashed potato, carrot, peas - Breadcrumbs, mild spices

Procedure: Mix mashed vegetables with breadcrumbs and mild spices, shape into small tikkis, shallow fry or bake until crisp and golden. Serve with ketchup.

4. Mini Cheese & Vegetable Sandwiches

Calories: 200 | **Protein:** 7g | **Fat:** 7g | **Carbs:** 26g

Ingredients: - Multigrain bread, cheese slice - Thin cucumber and tomato slices

Procedure: Layer cheese and vegetables between bread slices, lightly grill or toast until warm. Cut into small triangles for easy eating.

5. Sweet Corn & Vegetable Poha

Calories: 190 | **Protein:** 5g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 30g

Ingredients: - 1/2 cup flattened rice (poha), rinsed - Boiled sweet corn, finely chopped carrot - Mild tempering (mustard seed, curry leaves, turmeric)

Procedure: Temper mustard seeds and curry leaves in a little oil, add vegetables and sauté briefly. Add rinsed poha and turmeric, mix well and cook covered for 3-4 minutes.

6. Vegetable Semolina Upma

Calories: 180 | **Protein:** 5g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 25g

Ingredients: - 1/2 cup semolina (suji), roasted - Finely chopped carrot, peas, beans - Mild mustard seed tempering

Procedure: Sauté vegetables with tempering, add roasted semolina and water gradually, stir continuously to avoid lumps, cook until soft and fluffy.

7. Idli with Mild Tomato Chutney

Calories: 200 | **Protein:** 6g | **Fat:** 3g | **Carbs:** 36g

Ingredients: - 3-4 mini or regular idlis - Tomato, garlic, mild chilli (chutney)

Procedure: Steam idlis until soft. Blend tomato, a little garlic and minimal chilli for a mild chutney. Serve idlis warm with the chutney on the side.

8. Cheese Dosa

Calories: 220 | **Protein:** 7g | **Fat:** 9g | **Carbs:** 28g

Ingredients: - Regular dosa batter - 2 tbsp grated cheese

Procedure: Spread dosa batter thin on a hot tawa, sprinkle grated cheese while it's still cooking, fold once cheese melts slightly. A dosa upgrade kids love.

9. Moong Dal Cheela with Cheese

Calories: 210 | **Protein:** 12g | **Fat:** 7g | **Carbs:** 22g

Ingredients: - 1/2 cup soaked moong dal, ground - 1 tbsp grated cheese - Mild spices

Procedure: Pour ground moong batter on a hot tawa, sprinkle cheese on top while cooking, fold once golden. Soft, cheesy, and protein-rich.

10. Vegetable & Corn Cheese Balls

Calories: 170 | **Protein:** 5g | **Fat:** 8g | **Carbs:** 18g

Ingredients: - Boiled potato, sweet corn, grated cheese - Light breadcrumb coating

Procedure: Mash potato and corn with cheese, shape into small balls, coat lightly in breadcrumbs, shallow fry or bake until golden. Kid-tested favorite.

11. Vegetable & Cheese Toast Sticks

Calories: 190 | **Protein:** 7g | **Fat:** 8g | **Carbs:** 20g

Ingredients: - Bread, finely chopped vegetables, grated cheese

Procedure: Top bread slices with vegetables and cheese, toast or grill until melted and crisp. Cut into finger-sized sticks for easy holding.

12. Simple Vegetable Khichdi with Ghee

Calories: 200 | **Protein:** 7g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 30g

Ingredients: - 1/4 cup rice, 1/4 cup moong dal - Finely chopped carrot, peas, beans - 1 tsp ghee

Procedure: Pressure cook rice, dal and vegetables with turmeric and a little salt until soft. Top with ghee before serving — comforting and easy to digest.

13. Paneer Tikka Bites (Mild, Pan-Cooked)

Calories: 210 | **Protein:** 14g | **Fat:** 12g | **Carbs:** 10g

Ingredients: - 100g paneer cubes - Mild curd marinade with a little ginger-garlic

Procedure: Marinate paneer cubes in mild curd marinade for 15 minutes, pan-cook on low-medium heat until lightly golden on all sides. Serve with ketchup.

14. Vegetable Semolina Pancake (Chilla)

Calories: 180 | **Protein:** 6g | **Fat:** 6g | **Carbs:** 25g

Ingredients: - Semolina batter with finely grated carrot and curd - Mild spices

Procedure: Mix semolina with curd, water and grated vegetables into a smooth batter, rest 10 minutes, cook like a pancake on tawa until golden on both sides.

15. Sweet Potato & Cheese Cutlets

Calories: 180 | **Protein:** 5g | **Fat:** 7g | **Carbs:** 24g

Ingredients: - Boiled and mashed sweet potato - Grated cheese, light breadcrumb coating

Procedure: Mix mashed sweet potato with cheese, shape into small patties, coat lightly in breadcrumbs, shallow fry or bake until golden.

Part 2: 5 Sweet Nutritious Treats

16. Banana & Peanut Butter Roti Roll

Calories: 180 | **Protein:** 6g | **Fat:** 8g | **Carbs:** 22g

Ingredients: - Small whole wheat roti - 1 tbsp peanut butter, banana slices

Procedure: Spread peanut butter on a warm roti, layer banana slices, roll up and slice into bite-sized pieces. Quick, filling, and kids can help make it.

17. Chocolate Ragi Ladoo (Naturally Sweetened)

Calories: 90 | **Protein:** 2g | **Fat:** 4g | **Carbs:** 12g

Ingredients: - Roasted ragi flour, unsweetened cocoa powder - Jaggery, ghee

Procedure: Mix roasted ragi flour and cocoa with melted jaggery and a little ghee, shape into small balls. A chocolatey treat that's genuinely nutritious.

18. Fruit & Curd Bowl with Honey

Calories: 140 | **Protein:** 4g | **Fat:** 3g | **Carbs:** 24g

Ingredients: - Curd, chopped seasonal fruit (banana, mango, or apple) - A light drizzle of honey

Procedure: Mix curd with chopped fruit, drizzle a little honey on top. A simple, naturally sweet snack most kids enjoy without persuasion.

19. Date & Nut Energy Balls

Calories: 100 | **Protein:** 3g | **Fat:** 5g | **Carbs:** 13g

Ingredients: - Seedless dates, almonds, cashews - Pinch of cardamom, 1 tsp ghee

Procedure: Blend soaked dates with nuts and cardamom into a thick sticky mixture, warm slightly with ghee to bind, roll into small balls. Naturally sweet, no added sugar.

20. Baked Banana Oats Cookies

Calories: 110 | **Protein:** 3g | **Fat:** 3g | **Carbs:** 19g

Ingredients: - 1 ripe banana, mashed - 1/2 cup rolled oats - Pinch of cinnamon

Procedure: Mix mashed banana with oats and cinnamon into a thick dough, spoon small rounds onto a baking tray, bake at 180°C for 12-15 minutes until firm. A guilt-free cookie for lunchboxes.

A Note for Parents (include as an intro page)

Every recipe in this book is built around dishes kids genuinely enjoy — familiar textures and flavors, with the nutrition worked into the recipe itself rather than hidden or forced. The sweet treats section is naturally sweetened with fruit, dates or jaggery, so parents can offer them without guilt. Keep portions small, offer the same dish a few times before deciding your child dislikes it, and involve them in simple prep steps where possible — it goes a long way in getting them to eat.

Note: Nutrition values are approximate estimates and may vary based on exact quantities and brands used. Recommend a nutrition-calculation review before final print if precision is important for clinical credibility. Portion sizes should be adjusted based on the child's age and appetite.